

Zebronics ZEB-650i SLI	Galaxy 650i LT	XFX MB - N650 - IUL9
		
NVIDIA 650i SLI	NVIDIA 650i Ultra	NVIDIA 650i Ultra
LGA 775	LGA 775	LGA 775
650i SLI	650i Ultra	650i Ultra
nForce 430i	nForce 430i	nForce 430i
4,800	4,800	5,700
Well priced	Well priced	Good overclocker
Slimpy bundle	Slimpy bundle	Slimpy bundle
72.36	71.57	71.41
26.70	24.89	26.44
36.16	37.18	36.97
9.50	9.50	8.00
1333 MHz	1333 MHz	1333 MHz
DDR2 / 800 MHz	DDR2 / 800 MHz	DDR2 / 800 MHz
8 GB / 4	8 GB / 4	8 GB / 4
5 / 2	4 / 1	4 / 1
Y / 1	N / NA	N / NA
N	N	N
2 / 1 / 0	3 / 2 / 0	3 / 2 / 0
SLI / x8 / x8	NA / x16	NA / x16
Realtek ALC885/8/Y	Realtek ALC885/8/Y	Realtek ALC885/8/Y
Y / N	N / N	N / N
1 / G	1 / G	1 / G
N	N	N
4 / 1	4 / 1	4 / 1
N	N	N
6.67	6.79	6.79
Y / Y / Y	Y / Y / Y	Y / Y / Y
Y / Y / Y / Y / Y	Y / Y / Y / Y / Y	Y / Y / Y / Y / Y
1.2~1.510v	0.83125~1.6v	0.83125~1.6v
1.8~2.01v	1.92~2.517v	1.92~2.517v
2 / 1	2 / 1	4 / 1
NA	NA	NA
SLI Connector	SLI Connector	SLI Connector, USB Bracket
7518	7527	7282
5686 / 11872	6078 / 12660	6082 / 12220
7438	7470	7510
8400	8525	8369
27043 / 18582	27071 / 18764	27182 / 18728
161185 / 87781	161557 / 87962	161206 / 87829
70 / 8 ms	70 / 8 ms	70 / 8 ms
5126 / 5132	5793 / 5783	5728 / 5722
16508 / 9230	16880 / 9686	16820 / 9692
71.4 sec	69.67 sec	69.24 sec
56.2 sec	53.1 sec	53.61 sec
229.5 / 116.4 fps	236.9 / 119.7 fps	237.2 / 118.5 fps
230.5 / 116.3 fps	231.5 / 117.8 fps	232.2 / 118.1 fps

If you want the best SLI solution that won't bottleneck two 8800 GTX / Ultra graphics cards and money isn't an issue, pick up the ASUS Striker Extreme for Rs 21,400. There is also a non-extreme version available, which is equally good and around Rs 2,500 cheaper.

If you want a really affordable SLI solution, look at Zebronics' ZEB-650i SLI—at Rs 4,800, you can pick up two 8600 GTs for the amount you'll save from the ASUS Striker Extreme!

If you want a 680i/LT motherboard for the plethora of overclocking options but don't want to spend above Rs 15,000, pick up ASUS' P5N32-E SLI or Galaxy's 680i LT SLI for Rs 13,800 and 9,200 respectively.

Our winners are the excellent 680i-bearing ASUS Striker Extreme (Gold) and ASUS P5N32-E SLI (Silver), for their mixture of raw performance and overclockability that will deliver the goods to these fraternities.

INTEL P965-BASED MOTHERBOARDS

An older chipset, the P965 still is an excellent product but it finds itself at the end of its life cycle, and therefore largely redundant with P35-based boards costing a few hundreds more. Do remember that the P965 unofficially supports the 1333 MHz FSB through BIOS updates, so will work with the upcoming Penryn processors. The fact that we have seen P965 boards running at an FSB of over 1600 MHz (overclocked) means that while the P965 platform may be older, toothless it's not!

Features

The very term *features* is synonymous with one board here—the ASUS P5B Premium Vista Edition, and about the only grouse we can come up with is its extremely long name! A near-perfect layout, detailed BIOS complete with superb overclocking options (second only to the ASUS Commando), and supreme build quality. But wait... there's also a remote control unit that allows you to control several functions including the ability to hibernate, power down and even play music. Then there's the additional tiny LCD screen unit (that looks like a PMP, by the way) that allows you to view important pop-ups such RSS feeds and will sync with Web sites when your PC is on. All this data can be viewed later even when your PC is off!

ASUS' Commando is another "Republic of Gamers" product complete with extra overclocking options, LED POST display and LED backlit power, restart and CMOS reset buttons on the PCB. The P5B Deluxe is a feature-rich offering that shares an identical layout (right down to the cooler) with the P5B Premium Vista Edition. The P5B-E is a lower version of the P5B Deluxe without a wireless access point and minus a few other frills.

MSI's P965 Platinum was the only other feature-rich board in this group—the MSI P965 Neo and Biostar TForce P965

were the proverbial plain

Janes—all the regular features you'd need in

a motherboard

without

the additional pizzazz

that the costlier

boards show off.

Performance

The sheer toppers in

terms of overall performance

were the ASUS

Commando and the P5B Deluxe—no

wonder these were the kings of the ring before the P35 based motherboards came out—and the performance increments are almost insignificant. In fact, all the ASUS boards gave better 3D Mark 2005 scores than the other boards in this category, proving that if you want a gaming platform based on the P965 chipset, you should consider ASUS. Memory bandwidth scores in SiSoft Sandra's test suite are also noticeably higher.

For some reason, both the MSI boards took a dip in the SiSoft Sandra CPU Multimedia tests. The difference isn't alarming and won't be really noticeable in day-to-day applications, but these boards aren't the best performers around.



ASUS P5B Premium Vista Edition
Features galore